

121 The Magi

Wise men from the east who followed a star, worshipped the child Jesus, and went home another way.

Matthew tells of "wise men from the east" who arrived in Jerusalem asking for the newborn King of the Jews. They had seen his star and come to worship him, and their question alarmed Herod. Micah's prophecy pointed them to Bethlehem, where they bowed down and gave the child gold, frankincense and myrrh. Warned in a dream, they went home another way. Matthew does not say how many there were, name them, or call them kings; those details are later tradition. Foreigners were among the first to worship Jesus, while Jerusalem's scholars are not said to have gone.

At a glance

<i>Name</i>	Greek <i>magoi</i> , KJV "wise men"; source of our word "magic"
<i>Who they were</i>	Probably star scholars; Matthew says only "from the east"
<i>How many</i>	Not stated; the idea of three comes from the three gifts
<i>When</i>	c. 6–4 BC, some time after the birth, under Herod the Great
<i>Key places</i>	"The east," Jerusalem, Bethlehem
<i>Key people</i>	Herod the Great; Mary, mother of Jesus; the chief priests and scribes
<i>Main passage</i>	Matthew 2:1–12

"Where is he that is born King of the Jews? for we have seen his star in the east, and are come to worship him."

Matthew 2:2, KJV

The life of The Magi

Dates are approximate (BC). Herod's order about boys "two years old and under" suggests the visit came some months after the birth.

- In the east

● They see the star

The wise men see a star they link to the birth of the King of the Jews. They set out on a long journey to find and worship him. *Matthew 2:1-2*
- c. 6-4 BC
Jerusalem

● They ask for the King

They arrive in Jerusalem asking where the newborn King is. Herod is troubled, and all Jerusalem with him. The chief priests and scribes point to Bethlehem from the prophet Micah. *Matthew 2:1-6; Micah 5:2*
- c. 6-4 BC
Before Herod

● A secret meeting

Herod calls the wise men privately and finds out exactly when the star appeared. He sends them to Bethlehem, asking them to report back so that he may worship too. *Matthew 2:7-8*
- c. 6-4 BC
Bethlehem

● They worship the child

The star goes before them and stops over the place. Rejoicing greatly, they enter the house, fall down and worship Jesus, and open their gifts. *Matthew 2:9-11*
- c. 6-4 BC
The journey home

● Another way

Warned by God in a dream not to return to Herod, they depart into their own country by another way. *Matthew 2:12*

Group notes

Key activities

Christians and scholars differ on what the star was: a miracle, a comet, a new star, or a meeting of planets, such as a conjunction of Jupiter and Saturn in 7 BC. Matthew does not explain it.

-
- 1 **Watched and responded.** They noticed a sign in the heavens and acted on it, travelling far to find the King. *Matthew 2:1-2*
 - 2 **Asked openly.** They came to the capital and asked plainly for the newborn King of the Jews. *Matthew 2:2*
 - 3 **Were guided by Scripture.** The prophet's words about Bethlehem showed them where to go next. *Matthew 2:4-6, 9*
 - 4 **Rejoiced.** When they saw the star again, "they rejoiced with exceeding great joy." *Matthew 2:10*
 - 5 **Worshipped the child.** They found him with Mary his mother, fell down and worshipped him. *Matthew 2:11*
 - 6 **Gave costly gifts.** They "presented unto him gifts; gold, and frankincense, and myrrh." *Matthew 2:11*
 - 7 **Obedied God's warning.** They did not return to Herod but went home another way. *Matthew 2:12*
-

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name the Magi.

Old Testament

Micah 5:2	A ruler from Bethlehem, quoted to Herod (Matthew 2:6)
Numbers 24:17	"A Star out of Jacob," which many link with the star
Isaiah 60:3, 6; Psalm 72:10-11	Kings bring gold and incense; shaped the "kings" idea

New Testament

Matthew 2:1-16	The only account of them
Acts 8:9; 13:6-8	The same word family for Simon and Elymas the sorcerers
Tradition	Names Caspar, Melchior and Balthasar (c. 6th century) and Epiphany; not Scripture

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What three gifts did the wise men bring (Matthew 2:11)?
2. *Understand:* The wise men travelled far to worship, while the scribes in Jerusalem knew the prophecy but are not said to have gone. What does this contrast suggest?
3. *Apply:* The wise men gave their best to Jesus. What could you offer him this week, in time, money or talent?
4. *Apply:* They went home "another way." How has meeting Jesus changed the direction of your life?